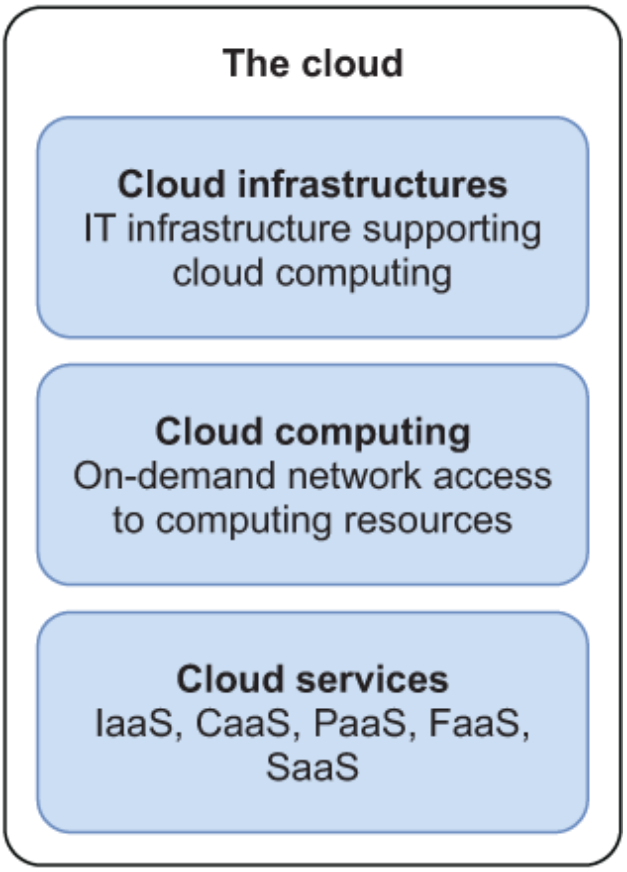


Figure 1.2 The cloud is an IT infrastructure characterized by different computing models and offered as a service by providers according to the degree of control consumers need.

The cloud is an IT infrastructure that supports the delivery of computing resources to consumers according to the cloud computing model. The National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST) defines cloud computing as follows:[3]

> *Cloud computing is a model for enabling ubiquitous, convenient, on-demand network access to a shared pool of configurable computing resources (e.g., networks, servers, storage, applications, and services) that can be rapidly provisioned and released with minimal management effort or service provider interaction.*

Just like you get electricity from a provider rather than generating it on your own, with the cloud you can get computing resources (such as servers,